

Prompt Engineering Basics

Service Learning • Practical AI Skills

Learning Objective

Learn how to write clear prompts that provide an AI assistant with enough context to produce useful results.

What is a Prompt?

A prompt is an instruction or question given to an AI system. A strong prompt clearly communicates the task, relevant context, constraints, and desired output.

A Simple Prompt Formula

Use four parts when useful: Role + Task + Context + Output Format.

Example: “Act as a study assistant. Explain spreadsheet formulas to a beginner. Use simple examples. Present the answer as five short bullet points.”

Weak vs. Clear Prompt

Weak prompt	Clearer prompt
Tell me about Excel.	Explain Excel formulas for a beginner and give three simple examples.
Make a resume.	Create a one-page student resume for an entry-level office assistant role using the details I provide.

Good Practices

Be specific about the goal. Give useful context. State the audience or skill level. Request a format such as bullets or a table. Review the response before using it.

Practice Task

Write a prompt asking an AI assistant to explain a topic you learned this week in simple language, followed by three quiz questions.